The Unknown Longevity and Influence of Religion and Governance

Introduction

This memo focuses on performing a political research gap analysis by illustrating the types of religious aspects in politics within a society studied in these academic journals, the types of methods used and studied by these articles, the frameworks and discussions in the literature, and the gap in understanding the uncertainty of the lasting effects of politics and religion within a society.

Different Studies of Religion and State

Four research articles focus on specific areas of this topic. Jones and Nisar (2026) study the political influence of Official Islam (OI) on Kyrgyzstan's society; Jiang (2026) analyzes religious organizations' influence and participation in Taiwan's political system; Chentouh (2026) studies the rise of religious extremism that started after the 1979 Islamic Revolution in Iran and shaped religious extremism today; and Campbell et al. (2026) examine the religious backlash that divided the United States along partisan lines, especially after the events of January 6th.

Types of Research Methods: Qualitative and Quantitative Data

Jones and Nisar (2026), Jiang (2026), and Campbell et al. (2026) use quantitative data and mass surveys to advance their research. These studies used original survey and pooled survey data, collected samples, and tracked political and religious behaviors among respondents using statistical methods. In contrast, Chentouh (2026) used qualitative data drawn from historical sources. The author analyzed historical events such as the Iranian Revolution, the Soviet Invasion of Afghanistan, and the Grand Mosque takeover attempt in Saudi Arabia in 1979 to argue that those occasions contributed to the development of modern terrorism today.

Frameworks in the Literature

The four academic articles focus on religion's effect on politics. However, each work focuses on a different aspect of how religion and politics intersect. In Kyrgyzstan, where official Islam is implemented, research often examines people's levels of political trust and religiosity in that context (Jones and Nisar, 2026). Religious institutions in Taiwan are a key focus of research, predicting religious attendance and political participation, mainly through generalized social capital (Jiang, 2026). Chentouh identifies geopolitical events, religious ideology, and socio-political grievances as factors in understanding the rise of contemporary terrorism in the Middle East (Chentouh, 2026). In the United States, religious and partisan identities are central to the divide this research examines (Campbell et al., 2026).

Gap in the Research

These religious elements answer literature questions that intertwine with politics and reach different conclusions. However, they do not clearly show how long-term religion-state implementation correlates with religion's political influence over time within a society. Theoretical and methodological approaches for mapping the timeline of religious implementation in politics are lacking. Little analysis examines how long OI remains influential in Kyrgyzstan's society and among its individuals. Although religious attendance and political participation in Taiwan are related, the timeline of that relationship remains unclear. This could give researchers a new perspective for studying and analyzing a timeline of religious influence on a government.

References

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